



Sumod Hajela

A long time ago in a place far, far away, the wonderful concept of bookmarks was born. Fast forward to today, the collection of a few hundred bookmarks in your browser is nowhere as useful as the simple text entry box on the Google homepage. If you have been bookmarking the Web over a couple of years, you know what a mess the most studiously organised collection of links can become.

It all begins with the problem of categorising. Bookmarks tend to be organised as a folder hierarchy where each folder is the equivalent of a category and various sub-categories. This is your personal taxonomy. Now you must answer this simple question—where should a link be saved? Eleanor Rosch, who has been credited with revolutionising the science of categorisation, asks, “If you’re to identify true or false, an apple is a fruit, you’re fast. A boysenberry is a fruit? A bit slower. A kumquat is a fruit? Pause: uuuu, I think so.”

Building a Needle Stack

Selfish, individual work can indeed have a collective effect—given the right tools and context

So where does a page about configuring a Windows 2003-based Web Server go for you? If you put it under Windows, you may not be able to locate it when you think of Web servers because you are thinking of IIS, Apache, Xitami, Abyss, etc. Web server software, and contrariwise if you are thinking based on the OS. If you put it under both, are you complicating retrieval or simplifying it?

Separating where the object is stored and how it is marked for retrieval is the biggest step to organising information the way our brain wants to get it back. The same memory could be triggered by many different stimuli. It’s hard enough to remember things as it is—imagine how hard it would be if there were only one handle to pull the memory out with.

Today, the new shared power marking tool is Del.icio.us. It’s a Web-based service that allows you to save your bookmarks online, with a twist. Much like Furl or Spurl or Backflip, it makes stored links publicly viewable on its home page. The twist is that you can associate tags—just words—with links, and those tags become publicly available too. This means that if you go to Del.icio.us (<http://snipurl.com/cxkp>) and look at Del.icio.us/tag/Apache, you can see all the pages people using Del.icio.us thought were related to Apache. Look at Del.icio.us/tag/Apache+Windows, and you get the subset of pages that other people thought were related to both these concepts. Any tag that you use that has not been used before only adds to the vocab-

ulary of the system. You can try any combination of tags to slice your view of links the way you want. For a detailed overview, check out this Us.ef.ul page.

The interesting new concept is the collective effect of selfish individual work. Because your link is added to a collective heap of tagged links from which people can sort out things of their interest and slap on their own tags to organise their view of the heap, it becomes a great medium for social discovery and meaning.

The concept of the Semantic Web (<http://snipurl.com/cxkv>) is a tantalising one, where all pieces of information on the Web are described by a computer readable global taxonomy so you can always find exactly what you are looking for. The forces that make Wikipedia a fantastic resource despite its incompleteness, shortcomings and serious problems of arbitration are being brought to bear around the Tagged Web concept. According to the Semantic Web, the meaning must be connected to the categorisation so the world can make sense of it. The Tagged Web believes that 10,000 monkeys can indeed create something meaningful. Just slap on words that make the resource meaningful to you, and given enough other people doing the same, the resource will be well-defined enough.

Whether you use Del.icio.us to browse pages or flickr (<http://snipurl.com/cxla>) to see photographs, there is a constant side list of related tags that encourages you to explore. In your own link collection, you can see tags that other people have applied to your tagged links or photographs. You can see who else is marking up the same things that you have.

Stewart Butterfield, CEO of Flickr, says, “We’ve done step one of relatedness of tags, which is just cluster analysis of how people tag, and then we suggest related tags. So if you tag ‘Italy’, it will suggest ‘Rome’, ‘architecture’, ‘travel’, ‘food’, ‘Europe’, etc. And it works astoundingly well.”

Says the scientist Howard Rheingold, “I look to see who the other people are on del.icio.us who tag the same things that I think are important. Then, I can look and see what else they’ve tagged... And isn’t that part of the collective intelligence of the Web? You meet people who find things that you find interesting and useful—and that multiplies your ability to find things that are interesting and useful, and other people feed off of you.”

The DMOZ Open Directory Project (<http://snipurl.com/cxll>) works on a system of trusted ‘editors’ responsible for a small slice of their category tree who are permitted to add links to their categories. While it isn’t languishing, there is a real shortage of people volunteering to handle the less ‘popular’ categories. With a service like Delicious where everyone is responsible only for their personal view of tags and links, the emergent behaviour will take care of that problem too. Part of that emergent behaviour are the many cool tools that hook into Del.icio.us (<http://snipurl.com/cxlc>).

If you are looking for needles, try browsing Del.icio.us links via fac.etio.us (<http://snipurl.com/cxlw>) for a serendipitous experience. ☒

Sumod Hajela, Associate Editor (Technology) is Digit’s Alpha Geek. His pastimes include creating new software during lunch hours, and mastering just about every computer-related technology that there is. Write to him at sumod_hajela@thinkdigit.com